



— BUREAU OF —
RECLAMATION

May 2026 Colorado River Mid-Term Modeling System: Ensemble Streamflow Prediction Mode (CRMMS-ESP)

Key Modeling Assumptions:

- Version
 - Model file and ruleset saved in RiverWare version 9.6.1
 - Model file CRMMS_v4.17_202605_ESP.mdl
 - Ruleset file CRMMS_v4.17.rls (loaded into model file)
- Model initialization
 - Observed April 30, 2026 initial conditions for all modeled reservoirs
 - Model run duration of May 2026 through September 2031
 - May 2026 Most Probable final unregulated inflow forecasts dated May 5, 2026 loaded into model
- Unregulated inflow forecast ensemble
 - All inflow traces are provided by the Colorado Basin River Forecast Center and dated May 5, 2026.
 - The Ensemble Inflow workbook includes the 30 ESP traces plus the official May 2026 Most Probable, Probable Maximum, and Probable Minimum inflow scenarios used in the May 2026 24-Month Studies.
 - For the Most Probable, Probable Maximum, and Probable Minimum inflow scenarios, the inflows from the third year are repeated for the fourth, fifth, and sixth years to provide a consistent model run duration.
- Lower Basin water demand schedules
 - 2026-2028: Water use schedules are based on those used in the May 2026 Most Probable 24-Month Study, but demand schedules in 2027 and 2028 may vary based on the Lower Basin hydrology, projected water supply conditions, or the Sacramento River Water Year Classification (SRWYC) for each trace.
 - 2029-2031: Water use schedules repeat the 2028 default monthly schedules in the out-years. Schedules may be revised based on Lower Basin hydrology, projected water supply conditions, or the SRWYC for each trace.
- Modeled Policy
 - On May 6, 2024, Reclamation published the 2024 Interim Guidelines SEIS ROD, which included modifications to Sections 2, 6, and 7 of the 2007 Interim Guidelines. The CRMMS-ESP run reflects these modifications in modeled operations, as well as the IBWC Minute 330 system conservation.

- For modeling purposes, simulated years beyond 2026 assume a continuation of the 2007 Interim Guidelines, as amended by the 2024 SEIS ROD, the 2019 Colorado River Basin Drought Contingency Plans, and Minute 323, including the Binational Water Scarcity Contingency Plan. With the exception of certain provisions related to ICS recovery and Upper Basin demand management, operations under these agreements are in effect through 2026. Reclamation has begun a process to develop operations for post-2026. The modeling assumptions described here are subject to change pending the publication of a Final EIS and ROD.

Changes to modeling system files since the April 2026 CRMMS-ESP release:

- Set Powell Target Annual Release Volume for WY 2026 to 6.0 maf as an input
- Modified the 2026 Powell Monthly Release Table with the new 6.0 maf monthly release pattern
- Added scalar slot and expression slot to the BlueMesaData object to indicate months when Blue Mesa elevation is projected to decline below elevation 7,425 feet.
 - Added the new indicator flag to the output control file and the Excel output DMI to produce Excel and rdf output for MRM runs.
- Minor modifications to internal Reclamation processes (database DMI and initialization script) to assist with DROA data management.